

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

native Jashore district of Bangladesh, had crossed over to India on an August night in 2024. He was escaping the anti-Sheikh Hasina agitations, fearing reprisals. Later, his elder brother Kalipada brought Kajal's young son Jit into India for medical treatment. With SIR, their refuge has turned hostile turf. Kajal and family are among those lined up at Hakimpur.

CHAPTER ONE: EXODUS

Hindus like Kajal are a minority in these migrant queues. Most are Muslim: masons, garment factory hands, househelps, labourers from units in Bardhaman and as far out as Bengaluru. Jahangir Alam has his family with him. Shilpi Akhtar stood alone, with a soiled bag and cracked suitcase, carrying "every bit" of her household. "I worked in a paper bag unit in Bardhaman. I made Rs 2,000-2,500 a month. That was enough for me," says Shilpi. Hadn't they acquired Indian papers? They say no. Instead, they talk of paying middlemen thousands of rupees to cross the border—even more to survive here. Kajal paid Rs 30,000 in all, Shilpi paid Rs 4,000. All that's gone waste.

Often, over 100 people wait for days near the checkpost, not budging till the Border Security Force facilitates their departure. The BSF verifies their documents—Bangladesh ID cards, birth certificates. Groups are then loaded onto trucks, driven to border outposts, and handed over to the other side.

This exodus of economic refugees is being politically read in one direction—as validation of the BJP's allegation that Bangladeshi influx has altered Bengal's demography. Union minister and Lok Sabha MP Sukanta Majumdar reiterates the charge that the Mamata Banerjee regime has obstructed border fencing to facilitate illegal migration. "They have been eating our resources all these years," he says. They have likely been contributing to India's GDP as well—as its cheapest workforce.

Bongaon, meanwhile, is bristling.

Takeaways

- **BJP finds validation for its illegal influx thesis in long lines at borders, but local leaders call SIR a "self-goal"**
- **Reason: fear among Hindu refugee settlers, especially pro-BJP Matuas, whose CAA dreams are still unrequited**

This is the cultural capital of the Matua community, a Dalit refugee group that migrated from erstwhile East Pakistan and later Bangladesh, fleeing religious persecution. Their spiritual centre is Thakurnagar, barely 10 km from the border. Over the past few years, many more Matuas and other Hindu refugees have arrived, believing the BJP's promise that the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) would grant them full citizenship rights. The SIR has left them vulnerable again. Their anxieties owe to a major technicality: SIR calls for proof of inclusion in the 2002 voters' list to establish a linkage with Indian ancestors. Many recent arrivals simply do not have that.

THE MATUA BATTLEGROUND

A pro-Trinamool Congress faction of the Matua Mahasangha just staged a 13-day hunger strike over the SIR—Rajya Sabha MP Mamata Bala Thakur was centrestage. CPI(M) and Congress leaders also visited the site in solidarity. On November 25, after a *padayatra* in Bongaon, CM Mamata lammed the SIR as a coercive exercise aimed at the 2026 assembly election. "Not one genuine voter's name will be removed," she vowed.

The BJP senses she has succeeded in fanning fears, and that if voter names start vanishing, she will be positioned as saviour. "It's a game of narratives. The TMC is far ahead of us," admits a leader. Union minister Shantanu Thakur, the BJP's Matua face, has tried to calm the waters in vain. A team led by state chief Samik Bhattacharya has submitted a memo to the Election Commission, urging clear communication to stanch the emerging risk. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been approached too, and is likely to hold a rally in Matua-dominated Ranaghat on December 20 to reassure the electorate.

WHITHER CAA?

Mohitosh Baidya of the BJP-aligned Mahasangha faction is openly rueful. "SIR is proving to be a self-goal. We are facing so many questions we don't have answers to," he says. "Hundreds of Matuas and other Hindus will be excluded. Many won't go for hearings. They are afraid whatever documents they have will be taken away," Baidya warns.

A sudden surge in CAA applications—40,000 or so—plots a desperate graph. Certificates issued: only about 1,500. Now, the Calcutta High Court has disallowed online CAA acknowledgement receipts as provisional proof of citizenship. Says Mamata Bala: "In recent years, several Hindu refugees entered India. Almost all were BJP voters. Now they will lose their voting rights." ■